



FABULA ULTIMA

L I C E N S E

STYLE GUIDE

This document broadly describes the standard terminology, writing style, formatting choices, and general design philosophy that have governed the creation of **Fabula Ultima** official content since the very beginnings of its development back in 2017.

Authors and publishers who intend to create content and products relying on the **Fabula Ultima Third Party License** should follow these guidelines and structures as closely as possible, so as to ensure proper compatibility with the official content as well as other third-party creations, both in terms of the rules as well as presentation, mood, and general design philosophy and ethos.

Please do keep in mind that your content cannot reproduce the **Fabula Ultima** trade dress (such as its color palette, graphics, and cover layout) and must not give the impression of being an official product from the **Fabula Ultima** line. This document still relies on that trade dress, but only does so for example purposes!

Fabula Ultima is a game by **Emanuele Galletto**, published by **Need Games**!

www.fabulaultima.com ♦ **www.patreon.com/roosterema**

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CORE PHILOSOPHY

Fabula Ultima's design seeks to balance a satisfying and empowering "crunchy" ruleset with an approachable presentation, while challenging several tabletop RPG defaults: a "hybrid" experience combining elements from traditional combat-focused titles with innovations and principles found in modern and independent storytelling games. This converges into a specific narrative premise, supported by a design philosophy that relies on accessibility, trust, mutual acceptance, and redistribution of authority:

The game wants a group of **3 to 6 people** to collaboratively and emergently tell stories about **found families of misfits** who learn to **love** themselves and each other, all while confronting their **past** and tearing down **oppressive and unjust authority**.

These principles are briefly discussed below; while you don't have to fully embrace them all in your work, it can nonetheless be useful to understand them.

BOOK SIZE

The reason we chose an **A5** size (148×210 mm, 5.8×8.3 inches), was to provide a compact reading experience, making the books intriguing, colorful, and affordable – doors to a world of playful experimentation, rather than hefty collector items.

LAYOUT AND FORMATTING

Each page is single-column, with frequent use of bullet points and "breaks" in the text, helping readers catch their breath and feel a sense of gradual accomplishment.

Highlights such as the one you are looking at right now, together with paragraph spacing and headings, all placed against a simple white background, contribute to cutting the text into smaller "bits" for the reader to easily parse and digest.

The use of **bolding** to indicate core concepts (in addition to keywords) guides the eye even after the first reading, when the user returns to search for information.

SELF-CONTAINED SECTIONS

Paragraphs and rules rarely carry over from left page to right page, and should **never** require page flipping. If you can't fit a rule explanation on a single spread, consider reworking its complexity to make it fit. You want users to find all information in the same place (that's why spell lists are short and part of each Class entry, and why the basic equipment lists are repeated during character creation in the **Core Rulebook**).

FRIENDLY BUT HONEST STYLE

The writing style shouldn't be intimidating, but should still be honest: point out if something may create issues or discomfort, be it mechanical or emotional (these often overlap in TRPGs). Be transparent, and expect transparency from those who play with your content; do not build your rules around users who seek to exploit them in bad faith, and write for your ideal reader instead – it will be easier and more rewarding.

CHALLENGING ASSUMPTIONS

Fabula Ultima redistributes several traditional Game Master duties and authorities across the entire play group, entrusting everyone with what some might fear is "the power to ruin the experience": on the contrary, we see this as enabling everyone to make that same experience phenomenally cool and achieve full self-expression.

Whether you see this as a flaw or virtue, it is the guiding principle for **Fabula Ultima's** design, so you should keep it in mind when creating compatible content.

Among these challenged defaults, a few are worth discussing in some detail:

- ♦ The system is designed to enforce emergent, unpredictable storytelling (emulating the over-the-top plot twists frequently found in JRPGs), and actively discourages prewritten stories, adventure modules, or "canon narratives". If you aim to create such content, you will need to provide alternate rules for elements that "short-circuit" the experience: classic examples would be Fabula Points, abilities that let Players ask the Game Master direct questions, Rituals, Projects, Sacrifices, and **opportunities**.
- ♦ Classes and abilities primarily seek to be **interesting** and **meaningful**, rather than "balanced": we assume the Game Master will gradually learn to create foes tailored to the specific needs and power level of the party, and Players will learn to assemble a party that is fun to design for, rather than beeline for optimization. Our aim is to inspire and support Players and Game Masters alike as they explore the game and understand its soul, rather than provide premade experiences that don't require them to exercise judgment or take responsibility for choices and mistakes.
- ♦ Finally, the game hinges on a "less is more" principle, and on Players reinterpreting and remixing available options. For instance, if a given character concept can be achieved by combining two existing Classes, think carefully before creating a Class that does the same on its own: odds are the resulting Class will be both redundant and problematic, due to its effects "stacking" with those of the existing Classes.

LAYOUT GUIDELINES

This section provides useful guidelines on formatting and visual presentation.

HEADERS

In terms of layout choices, **Fabula Ultima** follows a specific visual hierarchy with its headers. In descending order of importance, they are:

MAIN HEADER

SECONDARY HEADER



TERTIARY HEADER

MINOR HEADER

Main headers and **secondary** headers are by far the most common; on the other hand, **tertiary** headers are used to better separate important text sections that are part of the same secondary header, while **minor** headers are fairly rare and used mostly when a tertiary header has already been used, or when using any other header would be too heavy on the eyes and negatively impact the page's readability.

In general, headers of the same hierarchy will be arranged based on whatever logic best serves the point being made or the concept being explained. Barring that, they can be arranged based on importance or specificity (usually from most important to less important, and from generic to specific), or simply alphabetically.

As a final note, make sure to keep headers and sections well-spaced: you want the reader to catch their breath before engaging with the next bit of explanation, turning each period into a "mini-achievement" of sorts.

COLOR CHOICES

Use muted, pastel-like colors and keep the black text readable. Stick to one or two main colors at most, and then make use of **gradients** to provide variety.

FONT CHOICES

For everything other than **main** headers and decorative text, prioritize **sans serif** fonts reminiscent of classic, old-school JRPG guides. Keep the font size at 10 for the main body, and don't go under 9. Use good spacing, 12 and 11 points respectively.

HIGHLIGHTS

Use highlighted text to point out important rules and advice, to summarize previous text into an easier-to-remember principle, or to separate examples:

This highlight is used to draw the eye to an important rule, suggestion, or a reliable solution to a problem.

Example: this is an example of a highlight for examples... a sample example!

Highlights are useful because they break down the text into smaller bits, but don't involve any lines or contours; this makes them a lot less demanding on the eyes and helps preserve the visual harmony of the entire page. If there's a header directly underneath, however, do your best to end the section with non-highlighted text (such as what you are reading right now). Otherwise, it will look a bit unfinished.

BULLET POINTS

Use bullet points when listing things that can all be grouped under the same header (usually a **secondary** or **tertiary** header). They take one of these two forms:

- ♦ **Title (optional).** Text (this is the default form).
- ♦ **Title (optional).** Text (for when the above form would be too heavy on the eyes).

If you feel like there's a lot to say within each bullet point, you can split the list into different sections, each with their own header; and if the bullet points represent steps that need to be taken in a specific order, consider a **flowchart** instead.

WORDINGS AND EXPRESSIONS

Below is a list of guidelines concerning common expressions and wordings found in *Fabula Ultima*, as well as advice on formatting.

GENERAL CONVENTIONS

In the English versions of our books, we closely adhere to the following:

- ◆ **Singular they.** "They" is used for both the singular and plural third person. "It" is sometimes used for non-living entities with no intelligence, identity, or conscience.
- ◆ **"You".** When used in Skills and effects, "you" is normally singular and refers to the character using that specific effect – though sometimes it can also include the character's controller, or be plural when explaining an effect that applies to the user as well as one or more other game entities. Otherwise, it can be singular or plural; to avoid confusion, you can rely on expressions such as "you both", "everyone in your group", or "you and every ally present on the scene".
- ◆ **Players and Game Master (GM).** Both roles are always capitalized, signifying their equal importance. You can use expressions such as "participants", "members of the group", or "everyone" if you want to refer to Players and GM at the same time.
- ◆ **Page references.** When referring to the contents of another book, include the full title and list the page number in bold (e.g. "see **Core Rulebook**, page **114**").

Do your best to keep the text clear and approachable, without getting too wordy, and pay great attention when writing mechanics.

TIME AND DURATIONS

These concepts must always fall into one of the following categories:

- ◆ **Scene.** The scene currently being played.
- ◆ **Turn.** The turn of a participant in a conflict scene.
- ◆ **Unique timing.** The effect refers to a specific mechanical condition, such as "until the start of your next turn" and "until you **rest** again", or to a condition within the narrative fiction, such as "until next dawn" and "while exploring this area of the ruins".

Make sure to avoid mentioning minutes, hours, or similar real-world measurements when defining durations.

DISTANCES AND APPLICABLE EFFECTS

Much like durations, distances in **Fabula Ultima** are not measured in meters, feet, or other simulationist methods. Use the following instead:

- ♦ **Scene.** Use this for effects that apply to every active participant in the current scene; you may further define by using expressions such as "every enemy present on the scene" or "every other creature present on the scene who is in **Crisis**".
- ♦ **Travel days.** Use these to indicate distances on the **map sheet**.
- ♦ **Sight.** Already codified into any effect that involves **attacks** or **offensive spells** (⚡); otherwise, you must explicitly include it as a requirement if you want it to matter.
- ♦ **Hearing.** Use "able to hear" for effects that involve sound or voice; add the "and understand you" clause if the effect needs to convey detailed information.

In general, assume effects will be used on creatures that are within reasonable distance and are key participants in the scene — don't get lost in the minutiae.

WRITING AN EFFECT

Broadly speaking, all Skills and effects use the following structure:

- ♦ **Conditions (if any).** The conditions needed for the effect to trigger or for the Skill or ability to be used: common examples are "if", "when", "before", "after", "as long as", "during a conflict", "on your turn". If there are multiple conditions, the second condition is frequently preceded by "if" and any further condition by "and" (e.g. "During a conflict, if you are in **Crisis** and you have a **melee** weapon equipped...").
- ♦ **Costs (if any).** These are expressed as "you may". There's generally a maximum of two costs, and the cost of performing an action is written **before** any other cost (e.g. "you may use an action and spend 10 Mind Points to...").
- ♦ **Effects.** The consequences of using the Skill or resolving the effect. Note that these will be performed in the order you write them in, so be mindful of possible triggers and interactions. If you want to reinforce the order of actions, use **then**; if you want to put further conditions on secondary effects, use **if**; and if you want to provide the ability to choose one or more options for the effects, use "choose one/up to X option(s)", followed by a list of options separated by "; **or**".

Keep in mind that unless an effect explicitly says "can" or "may", it is **mandatory**.

MAIN EXPRESSIONS

Term	Related rules and conventions
0 Hit Points	The correct expression is "being reduced to 0 Hit Points", and it happens before Surrender, Sacrifice, or fleeing (for Villains).
Actions	Always capitalized and bold. The correct expression is "performing an action".
Additional	An effect that increases an existing amount (e.g. "recover 5 additional Hit Points"). Note that increasing an existing effect does not count as "causing" that effect yourself.
Affinities	Vulnerability, Resistance, Immunity, Absorption. Always capitalized, and must be listed individually (e.g. an effect that "ignores Resistances" does not also ignore Immunities).
Artifacts	Always capitalized.
Attacks	Can hit or miss; they can be melee or ranged (never both) and they always count as "targeting". The correct expression is "performing an attack".
Attributes	Normally written in extended form, capitalized bold; use the abbreviated form when writing Check formulas. Their die size can be "treated as if it were X size(s) higher/lower".
Bonds and emotions	Bond is always capitalized; emotions are always bold.
Categories	Always written bold (although "Category" is capitalized, non-bold).
Checks	Always capitalized, expressed as 【two Attributes between brackets, with modifiers outside】 (e.g. 【DEX + MIG】+2). The correct expression is "performing a Check".
Classes	Always capitalized; bold when listed as requirements.
Clocks	Always capitalized; the correct expressions are "empty Clock", "full Clock", "filling sections", and "erasing sections".
Costs	Can be divided, halved, ignored, increased, multiplied, paid, or reduced. Use "total MP cost" when referring to the MP cost of a spell or effect that has modifiers applied to it.

⚠ These wordings use the English version of the **Core Rulebook** as a basis.

Term	Related rules and conventions
Damage	Can be dealt, reduced, or suffered. It cannot be "increased" (use "extra damage" instead), and is not equivalent to "Hit Point loss": an effect that triggers on "dealing damage" will trigger even if someone is Immune or Absorbs it.
Damage types	Always written bold. Damage with no type can still gain and change type unless stated otherwise.
Defense, Magic Defense	Always capitalized, sometimes bold. Abbreviated as DEF and M.DEF within NPC stat blocks. Expressed as a fixed value (e.g. 13) or a formula (e.g. INS die +2) in armors, or as a modifier (e.g. +1) in NPC stat blocks and shield profiles.
Dying	Happens when a PC Sacrifices themselves, and also when an NPC dies due to being defeated or as part of the narrative.
Equipment	Accessories, armors, shields, weapons. The name of an item is sometimes bold (e.g. staff), but never capitalized.
Extra damage	A number that modifies the damage being dealt. Note that granting extra damage does not count as "dealing" damage.
Fabula Points, Ultima Points	Can be gained, lost, or spent. Always capitalized, never abbreviated (no "FP" or "UP").
High Roll	Usually abbreviated as HR , especially in damage formulas.
Hit Points, Inventory Points, Mind Points	Can be lost, spent, or recovered, and can never go below 0. The maximum values can be increased or reduced. Always capitalized, can be abbreviated as HP, IP, and MP.
Level	Always bold (e.g. level 20 or higher).
Numerical amounts and values	Can be divided, halved, increased, multiplied, or reduced (not below 0). Note that 0 is still a modifiable amount; if you want it to be unmodifiable, use "no" (e.g. "no damage"). Use brackets for complex formulas (e.g. [your level, divided by 3]).
Ranks	Always written bold (although "rank" is written non-capitalized, non-bold). The correct expression is "a soldier -rank creature".

Term	Related rules and conventions
Sacrifice	Available only to Player Characters. Counts as "dying".
Skills	Skill is always capitalized; Skill names are capitalized and bold (e.g. Melee Weapon Mastery). The correct expression is "using a Skill".
Skill Level	Always capitalized and bold; abbreviated as SL when found within brackets in the text of that same Skill.
Species	Always bold (although "Species" is capitalized, non-bold).
Spells	Can be cast, learned, or known. Offensive spells must be marked with ⚡ and can hit or miss. Spells are not Skills and are not attacks. Spells with a target of "Special" do not count as "targeting" unless the word "target" is used in their text. Spell names are always capitalized and bold (e.g. Flare).
Status effects	Always bold. Can be suffered from or recovered from. The correct expression is "suffering from [status effect] ".
Surrendering	Counts as "falling unconscious", and causes the character to lose any ability to affect the scene.
Target	Attacks, offensive spells (⚡) and spells without a target of "Special" always count as targeting; otherwise, effects do not count as targeting unless the word "target" is used.
Traits	Always capitalized and bold.
Turn	The correct expression is "taking a turn".
Weapons	Can be melee or ranged (never both), one-handed or two-handed (never both), and belong to a single Category (but some effects may cause a weapon to belong to additional Categories). They may have up to one Quality.
X or more	Used to prevent an effect from happening multiple times when several eligible triggers take place (e.g. "when you hit one or more creatures" triggers once even if you hit three).

WRITING NPC PROFILES

NPC profiles follow the structure presented below. Whenever possible, accompany a creature's profile with a set of **tactics** and provide a routine for the Game Master to follow or adapt, helping them avoid simply repeating the most powerful move.

Avoid giving foes any complex or hard to track equipment, make sure to include Vulnerabilities, and give them two to four action options, no more than that. Express their **personality** through their abilities, and use evocative names for them.

For additional information, consult **Chapter 5: Bestiary** of the **Core Rulebook**.

NAME OF THE CREATURE (rank)

Lv X • SPECIES

The creature's description, if presented here.

Traits: Four traits. Use "typical traits" if the profile applies to an entire broad category of beings rather than a specific, one-of-a-kind entity.

DEX dX	INS dX	MIG dX	WLP dX	HP	X ♦ X	MP	X	Init. X		
DEF ♦ X	M.DEF ♦ X									

BASIC ATTACKS

- ✂ **Melee attack** • [Check] • modifier (if any) • [damage formula] type damage, followed by any special rule or effect (see page 7 for **writing an effect**).
- ✂ **Ranged attack** • [Check] • modifier (if any) • [damage formula] type damage, followed by any special rule or effect (see page 7 for **writing an effect**).

SPELLS

- ☼ **Spell name** (⚡ if offensive) • [Check] • modifier (if any) • Cost • Target • Duration. Effect.

OTHER ACTIONS

- ⚙ **Action name** • See the rules for **writing an effect** on page 7.

SPECIAL RULES

- Rule name** • See the rules for **writing an effect** on page 7.

The icons used in the statblock above are part of the **Fabula Ultima Icons** font, which you can use freely on any project. You can download this font at fabulaultima.com.

SOME FINAL ADVICE

This section presents a few important points that you will frequently deal with when developing any material compatible with **Fabula Ultima**.

THE TRUE CORE OF THE GAME

The heart of this game lies not in its conflict system, Check resolution, or Skills, but in creating a one-of-a-kind, irreplaceable world together with a group of caring and enthusiastic people, spending Fabula Points to subvert expectations, embracing the unexpected, being playfully excited about everyone else's ideas, and collaboratively designing a cast of heroes and antagonists, intentionally making their lives hard, and showing how they grow, evolve, and change during the campaign.

Ultimately, **Fabula Ultima** is a hopeful power fantasy both in and out of game: the **heroes** of the story will find their true selves and help as many people as possible, while **Players** and **Game Masters** will be cooperative, kind, generous, and helpful.

EMERGENT GAMEPLAY AND CREATIVE OWNERSHIP

We want the group to feel their campaign truly belongs to them: creating a standard setting with many elements set in stone obviously goes against this, and the most unique parts of the system will push back. If this is the kind of content you like to design, be **upfront** about its nature and try to make it useable within the intended experience – perhaps it could work even better as its own separate mode of play?

TRUST AND INTENSE THEMES

Don't try to remove all possible sources of disagreement at the table, and don't rely on Game Masters as moderators: **embrace** making content that challenges assumptions and **trust** your readers to be mature, responsible, and healthy about the themes and existential questions you pose – JRPGs aren't shy about their message, after all.

THE ROLE OF OPTIONS

Abilities, items, and combat options are **tools for expression**: they define a character's fighting style, its patterns and personality, which are fundamental parts of roleplay. Balance is more about psychology and "vibe" than numbers; keep possible extreme uses and combinations in mind, but not at the cost of being true to the atmosphere and play patterns that your work should generate, encourage, or challenge.

CLASS DESIGN

Classes are the hardest thing to design; if you do, embrace and respect the system's focus on **modularity** and **reflavoring**. Provide at least two valid "paths" to mastering a Class, force Players to seek "wholeness" through synergy with other Classes, and assume that if you include a way to increase a given score, such as damage or Hit Points, people will stack it with at least one or two increases from other sources.

To avoid issues of bloat and endless cumulative values, consider creating "alternate Classes" that **replace** an existing option and **cannot** be taken alongside it.

MIND YOUR WORDINGS

Pay attention when wording rules and effects, use official contents as reference, and ask experienced players for feedback: the **Fabula Ultima** community keeps growing and many people are already veterans of navigating its rules, so get them involved!

INSPIRATIONS AND TOOLS

Some aspects of the game, and the related contents you develop, simply cannot be "perfect" for a group without adaptation, and that's intended – no part of our work is meant to replace the creative intellects at the table, merely to support them. Take Atlases, for instance: on one hand, their sample locations are bundles of ideas and hooks to be torn apart and salvaged for the needs of the campaign; opposite to that are the antagonists, designed to be inspiring experiments that will not be fit for all groups (or rather, they won't be fit for **any** group without adjustments). When you create content for **Fabula Ultima**, you need to choose between making it **flavorful and expressive**, or **adaptable and technical** – don't aim for a middle ground.

AND A FINAL REQUEST

If you're thinking of making content compatible with **Fabula Ultima**, you're likely a fan of JRPGs, perhaps manga and anime too. But as fans, we are tasked with examining and deconstructing the problematic tropes of what we love; and when we grow from fans to creators, we must ask ourselves whether the narratives and portrayals we are reproducing are healthy, respectful, kind, and uplifting. Never stop questioning your work, be mindful of where it may cause harm, take a step back when needed, and be grateful to all who helped you make your work a reality. Seek human connections rather than efficiency at all costs, and wield your creativity for a better world.